An Analysis of Demon's Souls and Remake Culture in the Context of a Digital Society

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This essay inspects the value of videogame remakes through a study of Bluepoint's 2020 *Demon's Souls* (hereafter referred to as DS-Remake), a launch-title for the PlayStation 5 (PS5) and remake of FromSoftware's 2009 *Demon's Souls* (hereafter referred to as DS-Original), and how remakes are informed by ideologies of digital society. It references DS-Original, *Dark Souls* (FromSoftware, 2011), *Bloodborne* (FromSoftware, 2015), and *Elden Ring* (FromSoftware, 2022) as a series of derivative titles, hereafter referred to as Souls.

DS-Remake exhibits greater graphical and musical fidelity than Original — but consequently made artistic divergences, to the umbrage of legacy fans, who believe meaning is thus lost: see Ratatoskr's 2023 video *The Demon's Souls Remake Is Inferior To The Original* for example; offensive changes include those to character designs and ambience. Meanwhile, few changes were made to the incommodious gameplay. For instance, DS-Remake preserves Original's marathon distances from checkpoints to return to boss-fights the player failed, despite Souls games iteratively reducing these distances. *Elden Ring*, for example, makes a habit of placing a checkpoint immediately before every boss fight location. In an interview with Polygon (2020), Moore, DS-Remake's creative director, reveals that in remaking DS-Original, Bluepoint kept "the core of the game untouched … and then

everything else [was] stripped away". Bluepoint preserved the gameplay while being liberal with the art – a decision informed by technology and ideology.

Remake ideology considers different attitudes to originals. Begin with Nietzsche's (2012) observation of the "antiquarian", who "preserves and reveres" history, through a connection with artefacts, in which historical essence perseveres. In this case, we can consider DS-Original the artefact, and its historical essence its value in relation to its context. That is, a reactionary game, unique among contemporary action games, and a game with incredible legacy through the Souls series and beyond. Nostalgia determines a game held in such regard is not great for its qualities but its place in time — a relic to which any change is condemned. Nietzsche warns antiquarianism falters as everything perceived nostalgic is regarded untouchable, and everything contemporary frowned upon; rather than preserving the original's vitality, this "mummifies" it in imperfection. Meanwhile a "critical" view of history, informed by past successes and failings, and their present impact, enables progress. Consider DS-Original's historical significance as the Souls series: DS-Remake should acknowledge where game features have originated in Original, and where Souls improves upon or disregards aspects – for example, reflectively incorporating the evolved boss return-journey. Preserving DS-Original's quirks risks alienating players with expectations forged by modern games. However, many mechanics could not be removed while retaining the essential experience, and an updated *Demon's Souls* loses association as the forebear of Souls, as it becomes impossible to draw a trajectory of design to *Elden Ring*. The historical essence, beloved by the antiquarian, disappears.

DS-Remake preserves *Demon's Souls* history as Souls' father, yet is inappropriate within its own context as herald of a new console generation. DS-Original was not meant to be marketable or mainstream, succeeding only within a niche (see Appendix A: History of Demon's Souls for historical context). Modern triple-A (large-budget) gaming is categorised by cinematics, massive worlds, streamlined and accessible gameplay — all antithetical to DS-Original. Even comparing DS-Original to modern and popular *Elden Ring*, the latter has an expansive world, more engaging boss-fights, and is less punishing: for example, *Elden Ring* does away with the lengthy return-journeys to bosses, and the World Tendency / Humanity mechanics of *Demon's Souls* / *Dark Souls* that apply long-lasting punishment to death. DS-Remake might have redesigned boss-fights – particularly the infamously-underwhelming Dragon God. Those who view the boss-fights as the low-point of Demon's Souls might be satisfied, yet antiquitarians dissatisfied; the videos *Ranking The Soulsborne Games From Worst to Best* (Catarina, 2024) and *Ranking Every Souls Game from Worst to Best (Including Elden Ring)* (Ember, 2022) expose popular perspective on *Demon's Souls* bosses, and Iron Pineapple (2020) *Demon's Souls Remake – is it actually worth it?* offers opinion

regarding how DS-Remake could have improved upon the original. But once "improvements" start being made, where is the limit, the sweet-spot between DS-Original and a modern masterpiece, where the remake is great among contemporaries while still being unmistakeably *Demon's Souls*?

Newman (2012) answers: preserve elements critical to a game's identity, the rest are mutable. He argues introducing a game to newer hardware creates opportunities for quality-of-life improvements, raising the example of non volatile progress-saving, which was impossible on retro consoles. Similarly, Moore notes the PS5's SSD eliminated loading-screens from DS-Remake. Had this been possible on the PS3, FromSoftware might have incorporated it, so it might be friendly with the game's vision. However, technological limitation sparks creativity: FromSoftware made stimulating use of loading-screens, without which player experience would be diminished: in DS-Original, loading-screens display art of characters within the lore who are otherwise not seen in-game; in *Bloodborne*, item descriptions and lore points are provided. Should newer design philosophies, not technology-dependent, also be incorporated? Newman's example of progress saving has become an expectation not only because of technology, but because now that there are more games to play, games must respect the player's time, lest they play something else instead: In the 1980s and '90s, there were fewer games worth playing, so people were content to spend longer repeating sections of games after a game-over to reach the conclusion. *Demon's Souls*, too, asks time-commitment of the player. Accordingly, Bluepoint might have improved the return-journeys to boss-fights. Boym (2001) distinguishes between "restorative" nostalgia — reproduction of past experiences — and "reflective" nostalgia — melancholy appreciation for a past that cannot be relived, because it is unviable within modernity. DS-Original's virtues may be acknowledged while modernising gameplay.

Brown (2023) highlights divisiveness of preservation in remake criticism, which features "authentic innovation vs. inauthentic replication", yet also "authentic historical recreation vs. inauthentic revisionism". A conservative remake is inauthentic within its context as a modern game attracting new fans. For this reason, Brown discourages focus on nostalgia, which solely pleases legacy fans, calling remakes adaptations — adaptation studies valuing remakes by originality, not authenticity. Corrigan (2015) notes each adaptation has "adaptive value" — the particular reason it is important. In Latour and Lowe (2011), adaptations are valuable for expanding the original; art is the aggregate of the original and reproductions, which construct a legacy affording intrigue to the original.

DS-Remake does not enhance DS-Original, its adaptive value limited to impressive graphics. And videogames, unlike other art, exist in an exclusionary space: unless they are ported to new hardware, they become less accessible each generation.

DS-Original, being PS3-exclusive, is obsolete; *Demon's Souls* is not a concept composed of both games, but a mantle now worn by DS-Remake exclusively, provoking YouTuber Ratatoskr to exclaim DS-Remake "parasites" Original: its success relies upon DS-Original, and its existence diminishes intrigue in DS-Original by providing a more accessible means of playing.

Latour and Lowe reference productions of Shakespeare as widely accepted adaptation. But these are visual interpretations of a script, whereas DS-Original exists already as an interactive and visual experience expecting no interpretation. Its intentional design cannot be reimagined to tell the same story. Furthermore, Latour and Lowe assert good reproduction inspires further reproduction. The philosophies of DS-Original have been iteratively reproduced in distinct titles, but only a large company afforded the rights to do so can remake Demon's Souls; no others are at liberty to improve upon Bluepoint's effort. The concept of Demon's Souls is now determined by DS-Remake, DS-Original's vision lost to history.

The "Penetrator" armour's addition in DS-Remake, however, was effective by Latour and Lowe's standards, for encouraging engagement with the oft-neglected and unique feature of DS-Original, "World Tendency", which Robinson (2020) calls a "fuzzy system", praising DS-Remake for making it "more explicit". World Tendency is a mechanic never explained in DS-Original, which affects the world according to the player's actions; the menu design of DS-Remake makes the current World Tendency more explicit. To obtain DS-Remake's new Penetrator armour, one must navigate multiple world tendencies, and the new Fractured Mode, to locate coins that may be exchanged for a key. See VaatiVidya's (2020) *The Journey for the Rarest Item in Demon's Souls*. The esoteric acquisition process necessitated community discourse, increasing intrigue in FromSoftware's bizarre mechanic. VaatiVidya notes that without today's online culture, an item so hidden could not have been added, for it would never be found.

Brown argues adaptation's purpose is "temporalisation", meaning translating the game for a modern audience, drawing from Edwards' (2016) interpretation of localisation as "culturalisation", meaning purging and introducing elements, making a game inoffensive and meaningful to new audiences. Edwards' emphasis for games to be "locally relevant" translates to temporal relevance. Opportunity for temporalisation is apparent when Moore claims we remember DS-Original being greater than it actually is: specifically he recalls the Tower Knight boss feeling epic back in 2009, but being much less so when he fights it in DS-Original today, given his standards are elevated by modern games. Brown understands the emergent remake culture to be founded in "cultural and economic processes" to revitalise old media for new generations.

“Culturalisation” follows the opinion that games excel only insofar as they communicate with an audience stereotype — players having different experiences is a failure! It dilutes art by imposing how the audience should feel. Such amendment, even seeking to ignite intended feelings within new audiences, expels meaning. For example, Bluepoint “improved” the Tower Knight battle by changing the design of the Fat Official so egregiously that the way he is perceived is completely changed, and so is the player’s attitude. Ratatoskr scathes DS-Remake’s artistic changes for demonstrating lack of appreciation for FromSoftware’s vision, claiming remakes should be approached with “humility”: if BluePoint cannot appreciate DS-Original’s art, rather than amending it to their taste, they should leave it untouched.

DS-Remake’s art direction is temporalised by favouring mainstream appeal. YouTubers Hydef Hyde (2020) and The Firelink Conspiracy (2020) note artistic divergences, including making models look more generic-fantasy, and the imposition of blue-orange contrast — a trend of digital film manipulation and advertising — with a disregard for DS-Original’s aesthetic. The UI is generic, whereas in DS-Original it was thematic, rendering DS-Remake aesthetically incongruent. This follows trends of media similarity. Malone (2018) blames UX replacing graphic-design: theory, not creativity, dictates design. Also consider “spectacular” temporalisation (Brown), i.e. the translation of low-fidelity into visual spectacle, which emphasises marketing and cultural significance – for DS-Remake, to market the PS5. DS-Original’s own identity, unique and reactionary, is ignored.

While Edwards promotes culturalisation for extending the appeal of a game, there is no mandate a game be for everyone – games tailored towards a niche will resonate more with that niche than games bastardised to appeal to an unintended audience. Especially in the case of DS-Original – a game designed to not be like other games, and which specifically invokes the challenge of older games in spite of the increasing ease of its contemporaries. While FromSoftware continue to produce alienating, yet acclaimed, games, Bluepoint tarnish DS-Original to appease the mainstream. Recall the clamour for FromSoftware to incorporate an easy mode in *Elden Ring*; yet they refused to compromise their design vision. Compare Krishna’s 2022 article *Elden Ring Isn’t Made for All Gamers. I Wish It Were* with Lizardi et al.’s 2024 list of diegetic ways the game can be made easier: *Elden Ring: 14 Best Ways to Lower the Difficulty*. Perhaps old games are so beloved because they are of a time with different cultural values and priorities regarding game direction; and the reason for which a game might be inappropriate for one audience can be precisely the reason for which it resonates so perfectly with another.

Artistic deterioration is a product of technology. Benjamin (1999) cites 19th century condemnation of photography as "blasphemy", for machines cannot capture the essence of things. Though he calls this an "anti-technological … notion of art" – it has merit. That art aims at capturing something beyond its materiality, i.e. in the artist's intentions and viewer's experience, is central to much of Aesthetics theory, e.g. in Hegel (2015). Bluepoint cannot, through photo-realistic graphics, capture FromSoftware's vision, nor DS-Original's phenomenology.

Benjamin deliberates that the "philistine" perspective "feels that [art's] end is nigh with the … appearance of new technology." Art reflects technological evolution — so art does not die, but change, and subsequently, return to classical form becomes conscious choice (Agüera, 2017). DS-Remake being aesthetically congruent with DS-Original would be antithetical to the demonstration of the PS5's endowments. Moore admits Bluepoint's artistic deviance, stating players who "like the starkness and despair of the original" can apply a filter, then discouraging this, for it does not demonstrate the graphical prowess of the PS5. He advocates filters as a means of tailoring the experience, but FromSoftware designed DS-Original in a specific way. It is not malleable, to be shaped into whatever players want it to be. If a player dislikes the aesthetic, they can play a game with a different target audience.

This fits with Lee's (2022) observation of "a collapse of … aesthetic hierarchy" causing creativity to be valued not for its aesthetic, but its impact. DS-Original is artistically expert, but DS-Remake is more valuable for its ability to sell a console. Unfortunately, what excels artistically within limitations of resolution, polygonal-count, etc. cannot be improved by scaling its fidelity. At lower definition, some details cannot be expressed, requiring artistic liberalism regarding which features to highlight, allowing player imagination to complete the image. This mandates those remaking games to make artistic decisions regarding how models looked in the creator's mind. Bluepoint's attempt at this with the Flamelurker boss was criticised such that they redesigned it: The Noclip documentary *Demon's Souls: Remaking a PlayStation Classic* (2021) records Bluepoint developers noting a lack of detail in Flamelurkers's original model, necessitating they interpret what it's supposed to look like. Their initial interpretation was disliked by the community, so was amended slightly, but many major artistic differences remain in DS-Remake.

Why would Bluepoint change art, not game design? Perhaps because new game-design philosophy is habitual — not considered until its absence realised. For Chun (2016), everything new becomes habitual, no longer exciting, for we seek what is on the horizon. Brown identifies the remake obsession as borne from desire to be "next-gen" trumping that to innovate. Graphics greater than anything seen before, and exertion of novel PS5-features, excite an audience more than modern game-design. Tech solutionism causes the notion of a game's technology

exceeding its design, stemming from “Californian ideology” (Barbrook & Cameron, 1996), a system intensely optimistic of new technology.

According to Moore’s law, technical fidelity increases twofold biennially. But such increase of processing power does not translate to apparent doubling of quality, or game-scope. So DS-Remake could only be slightly higher quality than DS-Original, raising the question of whether a remake of Demon’s Souls was warranted over FromSoftware’s technologically-restricted titles such as *King’s Field* (1994). Technological growth is increasingly less stark: today’s game-design possibilities are little greater than at DS-Original’s release. Game genres used to emerge with new console generations and increased processing capacity. Now we can do little except improve graphics; nevertheless Californian ideology influences technological innovation superseding artistic innovation within technological constraints.

Habituation affects graphics, too. Agüera observes technological advancement coercing redefinition of “fine-art”; our expectations of graphics evolve alongside technology. Games lacking artistic focus beyond realism become outdated once benchmarks are raised. DS-Remake’s graphics become habitual when all modern games have graphics as good, or better. Then DS-Remake must be assessed as a game, not technical demonstration. Newness removed, DS-Remake is unfavourable to DS-Original, for DS-Original’s considered artistic design preserves it.

Bluepoint’s remake philosophy — idolising graphics — is ultimately for marketing towards a new generation. Robinson writes that “What’s perhaps most important to fans … is that the remake look spectacular”, a sensibility borne from tech solutionism, and habitual indifference towards game-design. Unfaltering belief in technology’s power persuaded Bluepoint that a prettier Demon’s Souls on stronger hardware is sufficient, and greater than the original — while they bastardise art, and neglect game design, resulting in a game spectacular in advertisement, but aesthetically inconsistent with DS-Original, and mechanically dissonant with modern games.

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Appendices

A: History of Demon's Souls

Sony tasked FromSoftware with creating an open-world fantasy PS3 title to compete with Bethesda Game Studio's *The Elder Scrolls IV: Oblivion* (2006). When the project began to faulter, Hidetaka Miyazaki took over as lead designer and redesigned the game completely, against Sony's wishes. The project was already considered a failure, so he could create a game as unique as he wanted; consequently the game was a marketing disaster and sold poorly on release, in an environment saturated with incredibly easy games, finding success only within a niche who found it a breath of fresh-air among modern titles. Miyazaki's focus was creating an authentic experience, and the specific game mechanics came from that philosophy.

See:

- Matt McMuscles' (2020) *Demon's Souls – What Happened?* at https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rQ3_I10FXIY.

- KingK's (2016) *Demon's Souls Retrospective* at https://youtube.com/watch?v=nBZ5KF6iN6w&si=vKX7MNmh9qftIwUE